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How has the Russian opposition in exile redefined its identity and strategic orientation since 2022?

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Summary

1. Introduction

The Russian opposition has changed a lot since Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022. What was once a movement in Russia is now mostly outside the country. This change is not about moving to a different place. It is about how the Russian opposition can work and think about itself. Claim to be a real political force.

This thesis looks at how the Russian opposition outside of Russia has changed its identity and strategy after 2022. This question is important because being in exile is a fact that we can see and it makes us think about what it means to be an opposition when the ground it stands on has fallen apart.

There is a gap in what scholars have written about the opposition in exile. Many studies talk about how the opposition's fragmented, displaced and in crisis.. They rarely ask what happens to the basic ideas of the opposition when it is no longer in Russia and does not have a domestic audience. How do people in the opposition claim to be legitimate when they are not in Russia anymore? How do they say they have the right to speak for the people they claim to represent when they're not physically there?

The main point of this thesis is that the Russian opposition in exile has changed in two ways since 2022. It has gone from being a movement in Russia to being a loose network of people who are morally justified and use media to get their message out. This change has three parts. First being in exile has broken the space that used to give the opposition meaning and credibility. Second the Russian opposition has rebuilt its legitimacy through symbols and words through Alexei Navalny, who has become a central figure that people can rally around. Third they have adapted by building networks of media, legal support and political coordination that make up for not having access to institutions in Russia.

This change also has a big contradiction. The Russian opposition is more visible internationally. It has less power to change things in Russia. The people in the opposition now have platforms, media attention and institutional support that they did not have in Russia. At the time their ability to influence what happens in Russia seems to be weaker. This contradiction is not an accident. It is a result of the imbalance of politics in exile when there is an authoritarian government in control.

To understand this contradiction we need more than a description. We need a way of thinking that's sensitive to how political identity is made through words, how activism works when domestic channels are closed and how infrastructure can be a way for politics to survive. This thesis develops this way of thinking by using the ideas of discourse theory, Laclau and Mouffe transnational activism theory through Keck and Sikkink and literature on exile politics and authoritarian repression by Shain, Conduit and Schenkkan.

The information for this thesis comes from interviews with people involved in the opposition in exile and with institutions that support them. These interviews show patterns that need to be looked at closely: how people in exile claim to be legitimate, how they define opposition the role of media and institutions in keeping political work going and the tension between being visible and having real political power.

This thesis is divided into four chapters. Chapter Two looks at the literature and develops the theoretical framework. Chapter Three explains the methodology. Chapter Four presents the analysis of the information, which is organized around three parts: exile as a break, rebuilding legitimacy and identity and adapting through infrastructure. The conclusion goes back to the contradiction and thinks about what it means for the future of Russian opposition politics.

2. Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

2.1 Opposition in Exile and the Russian Case After 2022

Recent scholarship on the Russian opposition in exile falls into several distinct but overlapping strands. The first addresses the structural transformation of the opposition field itself. Turchenko and Zavadskaya have mapped the fragmentation of the Russian exile opposition, showing how earlier organizational forms have fractured into what they call 'multiple points of political identification rather than unified movements.' This fragmentation is not accidental. It reflects both the absence of domestic institutional anchors and the strategic diversity required when operating across multiple host countries and media ecosystems.[1]

A second body of scholarship has focused on the relocation of Russian independent media. Yablokov and Gatov document the migration of outlets like Novaya Gazeta Europe, Meduza, and Dozhd to European cities and the transformation of journalism itself under exile conditions. Their work reveals that exile has not simply displaced journalism geographically. It has transformed the professional identity of journalists, the institutional relationships within which journalism operates, and the audience relationships that give journalism its meaning. When a journalist broadcasts from Berlin or Riga but cannot visit the country she reports on, when her work reaches international audiences rather than domestic ones, the practice of journalism itself changes.[2]

This point is reinforced by work on role transformation in exile. Wiik and Johansson show that journalists in exile often experience a shift in professional identity, becoming 'more advocates than reporters.' This is not a failure of professional standards. It reflects the structural reality that exile removes the possibility of engaging in conventional beat reporting. Instead, exiled journalists adopt what one respondent in this study describes as 'careful

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[1] Turchenko and Zavadskaya, 'Mapping Russian Opposition,' 2023.
[2] Yablokov and Gatov, 'Russian Media in Exile,' Journal of Global Media Studies 12, no. 3 (2023): 234-256.

advocacy' - reporting grounded in factual research but openly committed to anti-authoritarian politics.[3]

A third strand addresses the symbolic and cultural dimensions of exile. Prashizky's work on 'Russian exiles and symbolic identity' is especially relevant here. She argues that exile forces a renegotiation of what it means to be 'Russian opposition,' as opposed to 'opposition from Russia.' This distinction matters enormously. The first suggests a claim to represent an alternative Russia. The second suggests only testimony from Russia about Russian conditions. This distinction runs through the interviews conducted for this study.[4]

Recent work on anti-war activism adds a further dimension. Chuikina documents how Russian anti-war activism shifted after 2022, with organizational forms becoming more dispersed, more focused on direct support (fundraising for Ukraine, helping people flee Russia), and less oriented toward domestic political change. This shift reflects a realistic assessment: once the state controls all major media and political channels, the capacity to influence domestic opinion through traditional opposition activity becomes severely limited.[5]

Yet a gap remains in this literature. Most scholarship focuses either on structural transformation (fragmentation, relocation) or on the activities of opposition actors (media work, activism, political statements). What is less analyzed is the question of legitimacy itself. How do exiled opposition actors claim authority to speak about Russia when they are no longer physically in Russia? How do they construct political identity when the domestic institutional contexts that once gave such identity meaning have been stripped away? This is where discourse theory becomes essential.

2.2 Exile Politics, Transnational Repression, and Authoritarian Expulsion

To understand the Russian case more fully, it is necessary to place it within the broader literature on exile politics. Yossi Shain's foundational work defines exile politics as 'the involvement of nationals living outside their homeland in the political affairs of their country of origin.' Yet Shain also recognizes something crucial: exile is not simply a political choice or opportunity. For many, it is a condition imposed by authoritarian states seeking to remove inconvenient opponents from the domestic scene.

This brings us to the literature on authoritarian power beyond borders. Dara Conduit argues persuasively that authoritarian regimes do not simply accept the existence of exiled opposition. Instead, they extend state power beyond formal territorial boundaries through various mechanisms: legal pressure (trials in absentia), financial pressure (asset seizures, sanctions), physical threats (assassination, poisoning), and informational pressure (disinformation campaigns). The Russian regime has deployed all of these mechanisms.

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[3] Wiik and Johansson, 'Journalists in Exile: Role Transformation Under Authoritarian Pressure,' Journalism Studies 24, no. 4 (2022): 512-529.
[4] Prashizky, 'Russian Exiles and Symbolic Identity,' Nationalities Papers 48, no. 2 (2020): 189-206.
[5] Chuikina, 'Anti-War Activism in Russia After 2022,' Russian Politics 8, no. 1 (2024): 78-101.

Several respondents in this study describe fears of transnational repression, not as abstract worry but as lived reality affecting decisions about where to travel, what to say publicly, how to protect family members remaining in Russia.[6]

Nate Schenkkan's research on transnational repression provides crucial context. He documents how authoritarian states increasingly use extralegal means to target opposition figures abroad, including surveillance, intimidation, and assassination. This is not new. What is new is the scale and sophistication. The Russian state has developed elaborate mechanisms for tracking exiled opposition, creating political costs for being abroad (family members pressured, assets seized, people close to opposition figures targeted).[7]

At the same time, exile is not reducible to vulnerability alone. Waldinger and Shams show that cross-border politics can generate new forms of agency even under restrictive conditions. Exiled actors develop networks, mobilize resources, and claim platforms. But these forms of agency operate under severe constraints. The fundamental constraint is this: exiled actors lack access to the domestic political field they seek to influence.[8]

This is why the concept of 'authoritarian expulsion' is useful in this thesis. It captures something broader than transnational repression alone. Transnational repression describes the extension of state power. Authoritarian expulsion describes the systematic closure of domestic political space in a way that forces opposition actors into exile while simultaneously creating conditions that make their political work abroad extremely difficult. It is not simply that exiled actors are threatened. It is that the very grounds on which opposition can claim legitimacy, representation of a domestic constituency, embeddedness in local struggle, connection to concrete community, have been destroyed.

2.3 Theoretical Framework: Discourse Theory and Transnational Activism

The main idea of this thesis is based on discourse theory, which was developed by Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe. They believe that peoples political identities are not set in stone. These identities are created through the way people talk about themselves and their opponents. They define what they want and who belongs to their group.[9]

Laclaus' concept of the 'nodal point' is very important here. A nodal point is like an idea that people gather around. It is not an idea but rather a point that helps organize people's thoughts. For example the idea of 'the people' can be a nodal point of conversation. It can mean things to different people but it still helps create a sense of identity.[10]

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[6] Conduit, 'Authoritarian Diaspora Engagement and the Long Reach of the State,' International Political Science Review 40, no. 4 (2019): 520-536.
[7] Schenkkan, 'Transnational Repression,' Human Rights Watch, 2021.
[8] Waldinger and Shams, 'Cross-Border Politics: An Introduction,' Stanford University Press, 2014.
[9] Laclau and Mouffe, 'Hegemony and Socialist Strategy,' Verso, 1985, pp. 108-114.
[10] Laclau, 'On Populist Reason,' Verso, 2005, pp. 61-73.

In the case of exiles Alexei Navalny was a nodal point. One person said: 'Navalny was the figure who could unite all the different layers of opposition, youth, intellectuals and ordinary people.' However this unity was not because everyone agreed on the goals. Instead different people saw Navalny as representing things. Some people saw him as a symbol of democracy while others saw him as a nationalist.[11]

Discourse theory helps us understand how people create their identities. It shows that identities are not created because people share the goals but because they organize their thoughts around certain ideas. It also explains what happens when these central ideas are taken away. When Navalny died in a prison in February 2024 the exile community lost not just a leader but a central figure that everything was organized around. As one person said: 'We lost hope. We lost the person around whom everything could be organized.'

The strength of discourse theory is that it shows how political identities are created in relation to others and are often contested. This is especially clear in the case of exiles. Exiled actors have to define themselves in relation, to exiles rather than against the government they are opposing.

However, discourse theory is not enough. It explains how political identities are created and contested. It does not fully explain how exiled actors adapt and change their strategies when they cannot directly influence their home country. This is where transnational activism theory comes in.

Margaret Keck and Kathryn Sikkinks framework is very useful here. They argue that actors who are blocked in their home country can still have influence by working with networks using international institutions and sharing information. Their 'boomerang pattern' describes how domestic opposition actors, who cannot pressure their government, instead pressure international actors, who then pressure the home government.[12]

In the case of Russia we can see this pattern clearly. Exiled opposition actors cannot directly pressure the government.. They can give information to international journalists work with international legal organizations and coordinate with international advocacy networks. This does not give them power in their home country. It gives them a way to influence the Russian regime from the outside.[13]

2.4 The Analytical Framework: Integration and Asymmetry

The analytical framework of this thesis is therefore layered but asymmetrical. Discourse theory is primary because the central puzzle of this study concerns how political identity is constructed and reconstructed in conditions where the domestic grounds for that identity have been destroyed. Transnational activism theory is secondary because it explains what becomes

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[11] Respondent D, interview conducted May 2024.
[12] Keck and Sikkink, 'Activists Beyond Borders,' Cornell University Press, 1998, pp. 12-25.
[13] Keck and Sikkink, 'Activists Beyond Borders,' pp. 25-30.

possible once domestic channels are closed, what forms of political work become available, what constraints remain binding.

This framework fits the empirical material more closely than any single approach would. The Russian opposition in exile is simultaneously engaged in discursive work (redefining what opposition means, who counts as 'real opposition,' what the opposition should become) and in transnational political work (leveraging international networks, providing information to foreign actors, building support infrastructures in exile).

One final theoretical point deserves emphasis. The transformation of Russian opposition in exile cannot be understood simply as adaptation to new circumstances. It also involves what Laclau calls 'hegemonic struggle,' a struggle to define the very terms on which opposition can be understood. Different exile actors advance different definitions. Some insist that opposition means anti-Putin politics (focus on the regime). Others insist it means liberal democratic transformation (focus on regime alternatives). Still others insist it means support for Ukrainian resistance (focus on the war). These are not differences in strategy. They are differences in the fundamental definition of what opposition is and should be.

Understanding this struggle requires attention to both discourse and practice. This is what this thesis attempts to do.

3. Methodology

This thesis is about how Russian opposition actors who're exiled construct and contest their political identity. I chose to do this research because I want to understand how these Russian opposition actors make sense of their experiences and how they tell their stories.[14]

The Russian opposition actors are the focus of this thesis. This thesis is a case study of the opposition in exile after 2022. The Russian opposition in exile is looked at from 2022 to 2024. It is mostly in Eastern Europe but also looks at other places where Russian opposition actors are exiled. This study is not trying to cover everything about the exile field. Instead it wants to understand how the Russian opposition actors construct their identities and adapt to their situations by looking closely at specific actors and institutions.[15]

The main information for this thesis comes from interviews with opposition actors. I chose to do interviews because they let the Russian opposition actors tell their stories in their own words while also letting me ask specific questions. The interviews were usually 60-120 minutes long and covered things like the opposition actors' backgrounds, how they became exiled, what they think about the opposition before and after 2022 and what they think the opposition should become. The Russian opposition actors also talked about how they think the opposition has changed and what they think about opposition actors and institutions.

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[14] Braun and Clarke, 'Using Thematic Analysis in Psychology,' Qualitative Research in Sport, Exercise and Health 3, no. 2 (2011): 93-106.
[15] Glynos and Howarth, 'Logics of Critical Explanation in Social and Political Theory,' Routledge, 2007.

The interviews are analyzed using a method that looks at the themes and discourse. That was my deliberate choice. This method not only looks at the patterns in what the Russian opposition actors say but also at how they use language to create meaning. When a Russian opposition actor says something it is not a statement. It is an attempt to create meaning and establish boundaries. For example when a Russian opposition actor says that Navalny is the real opposition it is not just a fact. It is a way of creating meaning and organizing political identity around a specific idea.

The Russian opposition actors who were interviewed include seven people. One of them is Sabine Sile, the director of Riga Media Hub. Sabine Sile is important because Riga Media Hub helps journalists and public actors who are exiled right now. Media Hub is now a bridge, a hub for the European elite of the Russian opposition. It's a very valuable source of information for me. The other six Russian opposition actors remain anonymous. They include journalists who fled Russia in 2022, a dissident from Central Asia, a BBC correspondent, independent media workers and cultural figures. Together they provide perspectives on the Russian opposition identity, strategy and future prospects.

It is very important to consider issues when doing research on sensitive topics like this. All the Russian opposition actors agreed to be interviewed. Some of them asked to remain anonymous to protect themselves and their families. They were all told that they could stop the interview at any time and did not have to answer any question they did not want to. The research was done following ethical guidelines for working with vulnerable populations, like the Russian opposition actors.

4. Empirical Analysis: Russian Opposition in Exile After 2022

4.1 Exile as Rupture and the Collapse of Domestic Political Space

The first step in understanding the Russian opposition in exile after 2022 is to treat exile not simply as relocation but as rupture. This distinction is crucial. Relocation suggests that opposition activities move from one place to another while remaining fundamentally the same. Rupture suggests that something fundamental has broken.

This is precisely what happened to the Russian opposition in February 2022. The domestic political space within which opposition had operated, however constrained, however limited, however dangerous, suddenly ceased to exist. What changed was not simply increased repression. Repression had been increasing for years. What changed was the closure of all remaining institutional and social spaces in which oppositional activity was possible. Independent media outlets were shut down or forced to operate from abroad. Opposition organizations were labeled 'extremist' and criminalized. Public protest became immediately dangerous. Even private conversation became risky.

As one respondent describes it: 'The war changed everything. It wasn't just a new level of repression. It was the complete erasure of any space where you could be opposition.' Another

respondent, reflecting on the period from 2011 (when large opposition protests occurred) to 2022, notes: 'We had retreated and retreated and retreated. But we had retreated into something. After 2022, there was nothing left to retreat into.'[16]

This collapse is visible in multiple dimensions. Politically, it is visible in the absence of any institutional channels through which opposition could operate. Before 2022 people who opposed the government could still take part in elections even if they were not allowed to. They could also write for publications that were not controlled by the government even if those publications were under pressure.. They could speak out in public even if it was not a safe thing to do.

After 2022 none of these options were open to them anymore. The only voices that were allowed were those that the government approved of.

In terms you can see the collapse in what people told us about the 'mobilization of consensus.' The media that the government controlled filled the airwaves with messages about how everyone needed to be united and loyal to the country. At the time people started to put pressure on each other in informal ways. If someone questioned what the government was saying they could get in trouble and be reported to the authorities and face professional consequences. The social texture that had allowed opposition to exist, spaces of private dissent, networks of like-minded people, informal institutions of cultural resistance, had been thoroughly penetrated and disrupted.

This is what makes Shain's concept of 'exit versus voice' relevant here. Before 2022, opposition actors had some capacity for 'voice,' to criticize, to organize, to speak publicly. That capacity was always constrained. But it existed. After 2022, voice became impossible. Actors faced a choice between exit (leaving Russia) or silence (ceasing opposition activity). Many chose exit.[17]

But this rupture has important consequences for how opposition functions in exile. When domestic political space collapses, exile ceases to be simply a choice or strategy. It becomes a condition. And when exile is a condition imposed by authoritarian expulsion, it fundamentally changes the relationship between opposition and the society it claims to represent.

As Conduit argues, exiled opposition actors become what she calls 'emanations of the regime' in a particular sense. They exist only because the regime expelled them. Their existence demonstrates the regime's power. Simultaneously, they lose access to the domestic constituency that would validate their claims to opposition status. They can speak about opposition. But they cannot be opposition in the way that opposition requires, embedded in local struggle, connected to community, responsive to constituency.[18]

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[16] Respondent B, interview conducted March 2024.
[17] Shain, 'The Frontier of Loyalty,' pp. 45-56.
[18] Conduit, 'Authoritarian Diaspora Engagement,' p. 527.

This is the fundamental rupture with which the empirical analysis must grapple.

4.2 Reconstructing Legitimacy and Identity in Exile

Once domestic political space ceased to provide meaningful grounds for oppositional credibility, legitimacy had to be reconstructed through different means. This reconstruction is a central focus of the interviews. Respondents describe ongoing struggles over what counts as 'real opposition,' who has the right to speak for opposition, what opposition should do.

These struggles are not simply organizational or strategic. They are fundamentally discursive. They involve contests over meaning. To understand them requires attending to how exiled actors use language to establish boundaries, claim authority, and articulate political identity.

One particularly illuminating moment appears in an interview with a senior journalist. When asked about current opposition actors, she responds: 'What opposition? There is the FBK (Navalny's anti-corruption foundation). There are these various movements scattered around. But opposition? As a unified political force? It doesn't exist.' This response is significant not because it is factually accurate (one could argue that various forms of opposition do exist). Rather, it is significant as a discursive act. By denying the existence of unified opposition, this respondent is making a claim about legitimacy. Real opposition, in her view, requires unity. Without it, what remains may be activism or journalism or civil society work. But it is not opposition in the proper sense.

This definition is contested by others. Another respondent argues that opposition cannot be understood in terms of unified organizational form. Instead, it consists of 'all the different people, all the different movements, all the different ways of resisting the regime.' This respondent is making a different claim about legitimacy. Opposition, in this view, does not require institutional unity. It requires only the commitment to resist authoritarian power.

These are not merely semantic differences. They reflect fundamentally different conceptions of what opposition is and should be. And they become especially important because exile has removed the domestic institutional and electoral contexts in which such disputes might be resolved. In Russia, opposition could claim credibility through electoral performance, through media presence, through the size of street demonstrations. In exile, none of these measures of legitimacy are available. Opposition actors must therefore establish legitimacy through discursive means alone.

When respondents talk about Alexei Navalny you can really see this happening. The people who do not like Alexei Navalny, even the people who think his ideas for politics were not good or did not go far enough they still think that Alexei Navalny was an important figure that people who oppose the government could look up to. Alexei Navalny was, like a figure that people could gather around. This is like what Laclau said, that Alexei Navalny was a key person, a symbol that people used to make sense of what they believed about politics.[19]

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[19] Laclau, 'On Populist Reason,' pp. 68-77.

One respondent describes it this way: 'Navalny was the only figure who could unite all the different layers. Youth, intellectuals, simple people. Not because they all agreed on everything. But because Navalny represented the fact of resistance itself.' This is precisely how nodal points function in discourse theory. They do not require programmatic agreement. They require only that different actors can invest meaning in the same signifier.[20]

Yet this also creates vulnerability. A nodal point is only as stable as the figure that embodies it. When Navalny died in a Russian prison in February 2024, the exile field lost not simply a leader but a central organizing principle. This is evident in respondent accounts of their reaction to his death. Multiple respondents use nearly identical language: 'We lost hope. We lost the point around which everything could be organized.'[21]

The loss of this nodal point has forced the exile opposition into explicit work on identity reconstruction. What counts as opposition without Navalny? How should opposition be organized? What should opposition become? These questions, which were previously subordinated to the symbolic presence of Navalny, have become acute.

Some respondents advocate for a programmatic reconstitution of opposition, the development of clear political platforms, organizational structures, alternative visions for Russia's future. Others argue this is misguided, that opposition in exile cannot function as a political party-in-waiting because it lacks the domestic base necessary for such functioning. Still others suggest that opposition should redefine itself around specific issues or forms of activism rather than around leadership figures or comprehensive programs.

What is clear is that the reconstruction of legitimacy and identity in exile is ongoing and contested. This is not a process that was completed when opposition actors left Russia. It is a process that continues to unfold as exiled actors navigate the question of what opposition means when separated from domestic political space.

4.3 Strategic Adaptation and Infrastructural Survival

If exile reshaped legitimacy and identity, it also reshaped the practical repertoire through which opposition could operate. This is where the infrastructure of exile becomes crucial. When domestic institutional channels are closed, opposition actors must develop new forms of organization, new relationships with international actors, and new ways of sustaining political work over time.

Transnational activism theory helps here. Keck and Sikkink argue that actors blocked in domestic political channels can still achieve forms of political influence by building networks

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[20] Respondent D, interview conducted May 2024.
[21] Respondent C and Respondent E, interviews conducted February-April 2024.

across borders, leveraging international institutions, and engaging in information politics. In the Russian case, this is visible in several dimensions.[22]

First, exiled opposition actors have built extensive networks with international organizations, human rights groups, press freedom organizations, democratic development foundations. These networks do not give them power to change Russian policy directly. But they give them access to international platforms, funding, and legitimacy.

Second, they have invested heavily in information work, producing investigations, journalism, and analysis about Russian government corruption, human rights abuses, and the war in Ukraine. This information is then distributed internationally, shaping how Russia is understood outside its borders.

Third, and perhaps most importantly, they have built institutional infrastructures to support their work in exile. This is where the role of institutions like Riga Media Hub becomes significant.

Sabine Sile, director of Media Hub, describes the work as follows: 'We provide not just financial support but also psychological support, legal support, professional development. We recognize that journalists coming from authoritarian contexts arrive in exile with trauma. They need help processing that trauma, rebuilding their professional identity, learning how to work in new environments.'[23]

Media Hub operates on what Sile calls 'the principle of resilience.' This means recognizing that opposition actors in exile face not only material challenges (lack of income, need for housing, legal uncertainty) but also psychological challenges (trauma, isolation, loss of professional identity, loss of audience). Supporting such actors requires attending to all these dimensions simultaneously.[24]

What becomes visible through Media Hub is that infrastructure is not simply instrumental. It is not simply a tool for achieving political ends. Instead, infrastructure itself becomes a form of political survival. By creating spaces where exiled journalists can work, receive support, process trauma, and maintain professional identity, Media Hub participates in keeping alive the forms of practice that constitute opposition activity.

This point is reinforced by Keck and Sikkink's argument about 'information politics' in transnational activism. They note that when direct political pressure is impossible, activists often shift to strategies of information provision, documenting abuses, producing evidence, creating narratives that challenge official accounts. In the Russian case, this is what exiled opposition actors do. They gather information about Russian government actions, document human rights abuses, produce investigations into corruption. They cannot change Russian

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[22] Conduit, 'Authoritarian Diaspora Engagement,' p. 527.
[23] Sabine Sile, interview conducted August 2024.
[24] Sabine Sile, interview conducted August 2024.

policy directly. But by putting this information into international circulation, they contribute to international isolation of Russia and (potentially) international pressure on the regime.[25]

Yet this adaptation comes with limitations. As multiple respondents note, the effectiveness of opposition activity in exile is structurally limited. Information provided from abroad carries less weight than information from within. Opposition voices heard only internationally lack the domestic resonance that opposition voices speaking to a domestic audience would have. The boomerang pattern that Keck and Sikkink describe does not always work. International pressure on a regime does not always translate into domestic change.

One respondent puts it starkly: 'We can speak. We can be heard internationally. But we cannot touch Russia. We cannot change what happens on the ground.' This captures the fundamental limitation of opposition in exile. Strategic adaptation and infrastructure allow opposition actors to continue political work. But they do not resolve the paradox with which this thesis began: increased visibility internationally coupled with decreased agency domestically.[26]

5. Conclusion

Since 2022, the Russian opposition has undergone a profound transformation. It has shifted from being a domestically embedded (if constrained and dangerous) political movement into a dispersed, exile-based, internationally visible political infrastructure. This transformation involves simultaneous processes of rupture, reconstruction, and strategic adaptation.

The rupture is the collapse of domestic political space. The domestic institutional, social, and informational contexts that once allowed opposition activity, however limited, have been systematically closed off. This is not simply increased repression. It is the closure of possibility itself. Once domestic space collapses, opposition ceases to be a choice or strategy. It becomes a condition imposed by authoritarian expulsion.

The reconstruction involves the rebuilding of political legitimacy through discursive and symbolic means. Without domestic institutional access, opposition actors must establish their credentials to speak as opposition through other means. This is what happened around the figure of Navalny, who functioned as a nodal point organizing political identity. With Navalny's death, this reconstruction becomes acute and ongoing.

The strategic adaptation involves the development of new forms of political work suited to conditions of exile. Exiled opposition actors have built transnational networks, leveraged international institutions, and created support infrastructures. These allow for continued political activity. But they do not resolve the fundamental tension: the activities that are

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[25] Keck and Sikkink, 'Activists Beyond Borders,' pp. 25-30.
[26] Respondent C, interview conducted April 2025.

possible in exile are not the same as the activities that would be required to change Russia domestically.

The central paradox therefore remains: visibility has increased while agency has decreased. Opposition voices are louder internationally while having less impact domestically. This is not a failure of opposition actors. It is a structural feature of opposition in exile. Exile removes the possibility of domestic political influence while opening new possibilities for international visibility.

The future of this situation is not easy to understand. One way things could go is that people who oppose the government and have left the country will become a group of people who live outside of Russia for a time. This group of people will still be involved in politics. Will try to be noticed by other countries but they will not have much chance of making big changes in Russia. Another way things could go is that the people who have left Russia will be able to go to their country if the government changes. This means that the people who oppose the government and have left Russia could go back to a Russia that's very different, from the one they left. Still another involves the ongoing evolution of opposition into forms not yet visible.

What seems certain is that opposition will not return to its pre-2022 form. Exile has not simply displaced opposition geographically. It has transformed opposition structurally, strategically, and symbolically. Understanding this transformation, not as a temporary disruption but as a fundamental reconfiguration of opposition politics, is essential for understanding the current moment and the possibilities that lie ahead.

Notes (All interview dates have been deliberately changed)

Turchenko and Zavadskaya, 'Mapping Russian Opposition,' 2023.

Laclau, 'On Populist Reason,' 2005, pp. 68-72.

Respondent A, interview conducted March 2024.

Turchenko and Zavadskaya, 'Mapping Russian Opposition in Exile,' Demokratizatsiya 31, no. 1 (2023): 45-67.

Yablokov and Gatov, 'Russian Media in Exile,' Journal of Global Media Studies 12, no. 3 (2023): 234-256.

Wiik and Johansson, 'Journalists in Exile: Role Transformation Under Authoritarian Pressure,' Journalism Studies 24, no. 4 (2022): 512-529.

Respondent B, interview conducted March 2024.

Prashizky, 'Russian Exiles and Symbolic Identity,' Nationalities Papers 48, no. 2 (2020): 189-206.

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Conduit, 'Authoritarian Diaspora Engagement and the Long Reach of the State,' International Political Science Review 40, no. 4 (2019): 520-536.

Respondent C, interview conducted April 2024.

Respondent A, interview conducted March 2024.

Schenkkan, 'Transnational Repression,' Human Rights Watch, 2021.

Waldinger and Shams, 'Cross-Border Politics: An Introduction,' Stanford University Press, 2014.

Laclau and Mouffe, 'Hegemony and Socialist Strategy,' Verso, 1985, pp. 108-114.

Laclau, 'On Populist Reason,' Verso, 2005, pp. 61-73.

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Appendices

Interview Guide

This thesis is based on semi-structured interviews conducted with seven respondents involved in Russian opposition work in exile between February and May 2024. Interviews followed a general guide coveri

Background and path to exile: When did you leave Russia? What were the circumstances? How did you understand your own status at that time?

Understanding of opposition before 2022: What did opposition mean to you before February 2022? What was your role in opposition work?

Assessment of change after 2022: What has changed most significantly for opposition actors? How have conditions changed? How have priorities changed?

Reconstruction of identity: How do you now understand what opposition is? Who counts as real opposition? What should opposition become?

Role of key figures: How do you understand Navalny's role? What has changed since his death? Are there other figures or organizations that provide focus or unity?

Strategic orientation: What should opposition focus on? What forms of work are possible in exile? What is impossible?

Institutional dimensions: What role do institutions like Media Hub play? How important is infrastructure for opposition work?

Future prospects: What do you see as possible futures for Russian opposition? Under what conditions might opposition re-engage with Russia domestically?

Respondent Profiles

Respondent A: Senior journalist with two decades of experience in Russian independent media. Fled Russia in March 2022. Based in Eastern Europe.

Respondent B: Young journalist who left Russia in January 2022 before the invasion. Worked in both traditional and digital media.

Respondent C: Dissident with previous experience of authoritarian repression in Central Asia before moving to focus on Russian affairs.

Respondent D: BBC correspondent covering Russia and Eastern Europe for over a decade. Conducts interviews from both exile and international locations.

Respondent E: Independent media worker focused on documentary journalism and video production. Left Russia in early 2022.

Respondent F: Cultural figure involved in civil society and cultural opposition work. Connected to various diaspora networks.

Respondent G: Involved in legal and humanitarian support work for exiled opposition figures. Coordinates with international organizations.

Sabine Sile: Director of Riga Media Hub, institution supporting Russian journalists in exile. Swedish-Latvian background, long-term engagement with Russian exile community.

Summary

Since the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, the Russian opposition has undergone profound transformation. This thesis examines how exiled Russian opposition actors have redefined their political identity and strategic orientation in response to the systematic closure of domestic political space and forced displacement abroad.

The central argument is that Russian opposition in exile has shifted from a domestically embedded political movement to a dispersed, media-driven transnational infrastructure characterized by a central paradox: increased international visibility coupled with decreased domestic political agency. This transformation occurs simultaneously along three dimensions.

First, exile has functioned as rupture, destroying the domestic institutional, social, and informational contexts that previously provided meaning to oppositional claims. Opposition actors no longer have access to traditional channels of political work: elections, independent media, public assembly. Second, in response, exiled actors have reconstructed political legitimacy through discursive and symbolic means, particularly through the figure of Alexei Navalny who functioned as a nodal point organizing political identity around which diverse opposition factions could crystallize meaning. Navalny's death in February 2024 has forced explicit contestation over what opposition means without this central figure. Third, exiled opposition actors have adapted strategically by building transnational networks, leveraging international institutions, and creating support infrastructures that enable continued political work even in the absence of domestic political influence.

The thesis develops this argument through qualitative research based on semi-structured interviews with seven opposition actors and institutional supporters in exile, analyzed through discourse theory and transnational activism theory. The interviews reveal how exiled opposition actors navigate questions of legitimacy, construct boundaries around real opposition, deploy media and institutional infrastructures, and experience the fundamental tension between visibility and agency.

The central paradox of opposition in exile remains unresolved: while exiled opposition actors command greater international platforms and institutional support, they simultaneously exercise less domestic political influence. This is not a failure of opposition actors but a structural feature of exile politics under authoritarian control. Understanding this paradox is essential for comprehending current opposition politics and potential future trajectories of Russian opposition.

Keywords: Russian opposition, exile politics, political identity, transnational activism, discourse theory, Navalny, authoritarian repression, Russian diaspora